Temperament as Reactivity and Control, Not Destiny

Early-emerging differences in reactivity, approach, and attentional control are measurable and moderately stable; they are not a parenting verdict or a fixed personality forecast.

GRADE: MODERATE-DIFFERENCES; LOW-DESTINY | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: EMOTION, TEMPERAMENT | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Infants differ in how readily they become distressed, how they approach novelty, and how they can be soothed or redirected. Gartstein & Rothbart (2003) used the Revised Infant Behavior Questionnaire to recover a three-factor structure—surgency/extraversion, negative affectivity, and regulatory capacity/orienting—that organizes those differences as dimensions, not types. The Chapter 9 plan treats this as a constitutional contribution to interaction, not a completed character.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

The IBQ-R is a caregiver-report instrument with factor structure recovered in a large infant sample. Laboratory observations converge on similar dimensions but are narrower. Rank-order stability is typically moderate, not identity-preserving. Genetically informed designs in the broader temperament literature show both child effects on caregivers and evocative transactions; this card does not claim a parent-to-child causal law. Adjacent: behavioral-inhibition-anxiety-risk.md is a narrower fear/approach claim.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Stability coefficients are typically in a moderate range across infancy into toddlerhood. Mean-level change is expected. A high-reactivity infant in a well-matched context is not the same developmental object as the same scores under chronic stress.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (caregiver-report psychometric trait with ~40–60% heritability, not an environmental exposure).

Parent-report is contaminated by expectation and current behavior. Culture shapes which expressions are noticed. Goodness-of-fit and differential susceptibility remain live alternatives to “difficult child.”

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Difficult temperament does not equal poor parenting or poor outcome. High reactivity is not intrinsically maladaptive. Temperament is not a license to withdraw opportunities or to treat the child as a finished type.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Match demands and support to the child without turning a questionnaire into an identity. Labeling destiny does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Gartstein & Rothbart (2003), Infant Behavior and Development